Level Framing: The Deliberate Step Down

Two sentences. Have this ready whenever the panel is wondering "where do we place him" - which is what "not sure how to place you" means.

"I know this role is a step down in title from Senior Director, and that is deliberate. I spent the last years running a large org; what I want now is to be close to a team again, owning hard technical problems and shipping models - that is the work I do best, and it is what this role is."

Notes for delivery

- Say it before they have to ask. The best placement is early in the loop - late in the intro or when "why this role" comes up. If you wait until the debrief, the panel has already filled the silence with risk.
- One crisp reason beats three honest ones. Do not stack the biology ceiling, the Seattle move, and the MBA in the same answer - it sounds like you are talking yourself into it.
- Never frame it as a retreat ("getting bored," "tired of management"). It is a move toward the work, not away from the title.